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INDIA HAS THE TALENT TO PICK DIFFERENT TEAMS FOR ALL FORMATS

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Indian cricket has looked in very healthy shape for a long time. I know fans and critics point out that there is no ICC trophy to boast of, but India has been a strong team to give shivers to any opposition. The year 2023 was another step in that direction, and I do not doubt that 2024 will bring home the much-desired honour at the T20 World Cup in the West Indies and the USA.

India's campaign at the ICC ODI World Cup was sterling for me. How India dominated on the way to the final was heartwarming. It brought back memories of how the West Indies would crush their opponents in their prime. The sensational run by Rohit Sharma was in keeping with India's strength. A title win should have been a deserving end to the team's campaign.

I want this team to realise they have the talent to play differently. I want them to play fearless cricket consistently. They looked awesome in the league stages and changed their tactics when they faced a knockout situation.

The final of the 2023 ODI World Cup showed India's reluctance to take the bull by its horns. Once Rohit Sharma got out and Virat Kohli tried to steady the innings along with KL Rahul, there was a subdued response to the challenge. The intent was missing as boundaries dried up. That was not the best strategy against an opponent like Australia. The fear of losing had crept in early. It is not that you win every time you take the field, but you can't give up that early. Australia were in deep trouble early in their chase, but they hit back. And that is how champions respond. That is what I expect India to remember in all their campaigns this year and in the future. India must learn to take their chances and convert them into wins. They have to make things happen. The

team has players to trust in tough situations. I want the players to feel secure. I want the team management to focus on the skill factor of the individuals and identify the players for the battles overseas.

I will pick Kohli, Rohit, and Cheteshwar Pujara for their outstanding records overseas. They are better overseas than at home. They were able to accomplish this due to their talent and support from the team management. I want the team to have a set of players who have the confidence of the coach and the captain. I don't think they have done justice to Ravindra Jadeja. He is a genuine all-rounder in every format and has to be treated differently. India has the talent to pick different teams for all formats. Some names can be common.

There is room for seniors like Kohli and Rohit in white-ball cricket. The transition should happen at some point, but I am not in a hurry to rush things. The 2024 T20 World Cup can be critical for these two stalwarts. I would also want a regular wicketkeeper and allow Rahul to concentrate on his batting. We have loads of talent in Shubman Gill and Rishabh Pant. I think Suryakumar Yadav is an amazingly innovative batsman. He has to be there to shape the winning campaigns. Indian cricket is in safe hands.

There has been talk of India being unable to counter the playing conditions in South Africa and England, but please see how the team has excelled in Australia. The pitches in South Africa were not ideal for Test cricket, and I will not judge the team because it failed to win the series. We should look to create challenging conditions at home to face opponents overseas, and the team should not just depend on the toss. It will help us win more matches overseas in the long term.

As told to Vijay Lokapally